Data Creators › instructor pack — risks and fallbacks

Risks and fallbacks

One rule covers most of this page: a demo that fails live is not repaired live. Show the output saved in the anchor notebook from the day-before run, say what the room would have seen, move on, and fix it at the break. The learners' challenges carry the practice; the demos only set it up.

Learner access and environment

Risk	Signal	Fallback
Catalyst plugin not visible in Copilot Chat	`/ai-catalyst` lists nothing; "repository not found" on the marketplace	An access request to the GitHub team, not a settings change. Pair the learner with a neighbour for Day 1; Day 1's artefacts are shared at the table anyway.
Dev container will not build or open	Reopen in Container fails; the first build takes more than fifteen minutes	Keep working on the host for Day 1 (nothing needs the container until Day 2 afternoon). Platform support contact in the room or on Teams from 08:30.
Databricks setup incomplete	`dpc-check` red; `echo $DBT_CATALOG` empty	Cold start: `mise run setup:databricks`, a new terminal, then `astro dev restart --wait 5m` on Day 4. Until it works, the learner follows a neighbour's screen and reads the compiled SQL.
Docker Desktop on a Windows laptop in the wrong mode	Linux containers unavailable	Switch to Linux containers (Docker Desktop menu); if the role is missing, the Docker challenge is done in pairs on a working laptop.
Astro started before Databricks setup	Cosmos import error ending in an empty catalog name	The cold-start fix above. Say it before the challenge starts and put it on the whiteboard.

© 2026 Decoded Limited · decoded.com

Risk	Signal	Fallback
Two Astro environments on one laptop	Port clash; the wrong UI opens	`docker ps`, stop the stray project, `astro dev start` again.
Transient Databricks errors on Day 5	“Error during request to server”	Retry. If it persists for a table, compare their numbers with the expected results in the Day 5 anchor and carry on.

Instructor laptop and demos

Risk	Signal	Fallback
Docker Desktop not running	`docker info` fails; Day 2 Docker demo and Day 4 Airflow stack cannot start	Start Docker Desktop first thing; the pre-flight has it. The Docker demo’s steps are also screenshots in the anchor from the day-before run.
Airflow stack slow or stuck on Day 4 morning	`run.sh status` shows no run or a queued task for minutes	Start the stack before 08:30. Show the previous green run’s status and log cells; the learners’ practical does not depend on the instructor stack.
Spark demo cannot start	Java not found; `JAVA_HOME` wrong	`source common/env/activate.sh` sets it to the Homebrew OpenJDK 17. If it still fails, the Spark diagram and the saved plan output carry the point.
Mermaid `quick_diagram()` cannot download mermaid-cli	npx hangs on an office network	Draw on the whiteboard or in Excalidraw; the prepared diagrams are PNGs and need nothing.
A Claude generation goes wrong or slow live	Long thinking, a wrong skill, a flat network	Open the prepared artefact in `courseware/common/running-example/` and review it as if it had just been generated; the review is the lesson.
A DuckDB file is locked	“Could not set lock on file”	A notebook kernel or a dbt process still holds it: restart the kernel, or `pkill -f dbt`. The scripts rebuild every warehouse from seeds.

© 2026 Decoded Limited · decoded.com

Risk	Signal	Fallback
Google Drive path with spaces	A script fails on an unquoted path	All scripts quote their paths; if a new command fails, wrap the path in quotes or `cd` first.

Guests and people

Risk	Signal	Fallback
A guest does not come (sponsor, platform team, bitemporal, Harness)	No confirmation by the evening before	Each slot has an instructor-led version in the anchor: the whiteboard script, the diagram and the demo. Run it as the plan says and keep the slot's questions for a later guest.
A guest runs long	Past the slot by ten minutes	Thank them, take two questions, and cut the next block's flex (every run sheet row names what to drop).
Extra attendees on Day 5	People who were not in the week turn up for the capstone	Name cards, a table of their own, pair them with a team for the discovery hour; they can follow Phase 1 at their own pace.
Mixed experience in the room	Some have used dbt or Airflow in production, some never	Ask on Day 1 and write the names down; give the experienced the stretch tasks and the Day 4 morning teaching slots; sit them with beginners during practicals.
Nobody talks in the whiteboard sessions	Silence after the first question	Ask a table, not the room; take the first answer and write it up; the anchors carry the answers rooms usually give, so add the missing ones yourself.

Time and content

Risk	Signal	Fallback
Day 1 overruns on discovery	The PRD comparison has not happened by 11:30	Cut the lifecycle exploration to a ten-minute demo and run the interview activity in the afternoon as planned; the data contract can slip to Day 2 morning.

© 2026 Decoded Limited · decoded.com

Risk	Signal	Fallback
Day 2 platform block runs long	Still on Spark at 11:15	Stop at the tools-together diagram; the Docker challenge needs the full slot. The scheduled-run diagram returns on Day 4.
Challenge 02 unfinished at the Day 3 regroup	Few pairs past C7	Regroup anyway; show the build on the instructor copy; pairs finish the marts after the recap. Phase 1 of challenge 03 only needs the seeds.
Day 4 practical blocked by environments	Half the room on the cold-start fix at 11:15	Run the controlled failure on the instructor stack for everyone, then give the failure-note exercise the prepared example.
Day 5 teams still in discovery at 10:30	No `dbt seed` yet	Call time. The discovery worksheet is complete when the consumer-backwards map and four STTM rows exist; the rest is the build.
Day 5 Phase 1 not done by 14:00	A team on domain-aligned models	The day ends when Phase 1 is done; presentations move to 14:45 and the other teams start Phase 2. Nobody is handed a solution; circulate with the section notes.

Data and safety

Risk	Signal	Fallback
A learner pastes real data or a token into a chat	Visible in a shared screen	Stop, delete the chat, say the rule again. All example data this week is synthetic.
The courseware repository is pushed somewhere public	A link that opens without login	It holds client material and recordings; it stays private. Share the courseware folder and the prompt library with learners as files, not as the repository.

© 2026 Decoded Limited · decoded.com